🗓️ Timeline & Political Cartoons: Reading

US History · Unit 1 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Timeline Events in US History + BASIC cartoon analysis

Name: _____

Reading the Past: Timelines and Political Cartoons

Historians put events on a timeline so we can see what came first and what came later. Order matters: one event often causes the next. For example, the Civil War ended in 1865, and the years after it shaped how the country grew west.

This year we study about 1865 to the 1930s. In that time the United States moved west, took in millions of immigrants, became an industrial nation, fought in World War I, gave women the vote in 1920 and fell into the Great Depression after the 1929 stock market crash.

A political cartoon is a drawing about news, government or society. It is not meant to be fair. It shows the cartoonist's opinion and tries to persuade the reader. Cartoons made at the time are primary sources: they show what some people thought back then.

Our class uses BASIC to read cartoons. Background: what do you already know about the event? Argument: what does the artist want you to believe? Symbols: what do the pictures stand for? Indicators: what do the words, labels and captions tell you? Caricature: what is exaggerated?

In 1871 Thomas Nast drew New York politician Boss Tweed with a bag of money for a head. The caricature and the money-bag symbol make one clear argument: Tweed was greedy and corrupt. Readers who could not read well could still understand the message.

Check your reading

1. Why do historians care about the order of events?

2. Why is a political cartoon not a neutral source?

3. Name the five parts of BASIC.